Hybronn: Critical Group Learning Review

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Introduction

This poster critically reflects on our group's teamwork during the simulation. Using frameworks such as Belbin's Team Roles (Belbin, 1981; Aritzeta, Senior & Swailes, 2007), Tuckman's Team Development Stages (Tuckman, 1965), Hackman's Team Design (Hackman, 1987; Hackman, 2002), and decision-making and negotiation theories (Simon, 1955; Fisher, Ury & Patton, 1991), we evaluate our group processes, challenges, and learning. The analysis identifies areas of strength and weakness and concludes with strategies for future improvements.

Belbin's Team Roles

Belbin's Team Role framework highlights nine distinct roles (Belbin, 1981; Aritzeta, Senior & Swailes, 2007). Initially, this framework appeared to offer clarity in allocating responsibilities, reducing overlap, and ensuring that both creative and evaluative contributions were valued (Fisher, Hunter & Macrosson, 2001; Batenburg, van Walbeek & in der Maur, 2013). However, as the simulation progressed, our role distinctions blurred and decision-making became collective rather than role-specific. While this inclusive approach allowed diverse perspectives, it also undermined accountability and generated inefficiencies. In future collaborations, a stronger alignment between role allocation and task execution would be necessary to preserve both clarity and fairness.

Names	Co-ordinator	Shaper	Plant	Monitor Evaluator	Implementer	Team Worker	Resource Investigator	Completer Finisher	Specialist
Charitha	7	12	5	5	14	3	8	9	7
Nay Chi	4	12	4	7	12	11	2	11	7
Akarsh	10	8	6	9	7	7	5	7	11
Preeti	7	3	10	5	9	13	6	11	6
Enes	5	14	9	6	12	1	8	5	10

(May not be 100% accurate) (Github.io, 2025)

Tuckman's Stages of Team Development

Forming: At the outset, our "Project Alignment & Team Goals" meeting emphasised communication, initiative, and accountability. However, once the simulation began, these commitments were deprioritised, contributing to later challenges (Tuckman, 1965).

Storming: Divergent opinions quickly surfaced, with members prioritising their own viewpoints rather than listening actively. This resistance created conflict and diluted our adherence to the agreed strategy. Some members had limited understanding of the market and the assignment which further intensified contradictions. The CEO's failure to take leadership further contributed to dysfunctionality, as some members were disengaged while others tried to take up leadership roles, which was poorly received. Despite tensions, we retained the original strategy to maintain cohesion and credibility.

Norming: In theory, this stage involves stronger commitment and clarity (Tuckman, 1965). In practice, several members continued to lack understanding of their tasks and refused to commit, resulting in minimal contributions and preventing full progression into this phase.

Performing: Despite persistent disagreements, our team managed to achieve reasonable simulation outcomes. This success stemmed from reliance on initial planning and research-based decisions rather than improved group functioning (Katzenbach & Smith, 1993).

Adjourning: Theoretically, teams disband with a sense of closure. Instead, our group concluded in a fragmented state, with discussions of splitting into subgroups due to unresolved conflicts. Only time constraints kept us together.

Resolution: Ultimately, our team failed to resolve conflicts due to a reluctance to engage in open dialogue, consistent with avoidance patterns in conflict management (Thomas & Kilmann, 1974). The avoidance of conflict resolution maintained tensions until the project's end.

Decision-Making Approaches

Decision-making within the group reflected contrasting models. Some members adopted a **rational decision-making** approach, grounding their choices in data and research (Robbins & Judge, 2019). Others relied on **bounded rationality**, favouring instinctive decisions with limited justification (Simon, 1955; Simon, 2020). These divergent approaches created friction, as evidence-based reasoning was often dismissed. Greater commitment to transparent justification and respectful engagement with differing perspectives could have reduced this conflict (Dane & Pratt, 2007).

Furthermore, team members conducted thorough secondary desk research that was valid and well-supported; however, only a limited number of the recommendations proved practical. The majority, although theoretically sound, were either unfeasible or unhelpful in guiding decisions during the simulation. This reflects the need for stronger evaluation of feasibility alongside research validity (Dane, 2021).

Negotiation Theory

Fisher and Ury's negotiation framework emphasises achieving agreements that create mutual gains while preserving relationships (Fisher, Ury & Patton, 1991). This was partially evident during our Year 4 decision-making, when debates over producing a luxury car versus a medium-sized model with premium features were resolved through compromise. By aligning with our initial strategy to target a broad consumer base, the latter option was chosen. This demonstrates the potential effectiveness of principled negotiation; however, such constructive resolution was the exception rather than the norm in our collaboration.

Hackman's Model of Team Design

Hackman (1987) argues that team effectiveness is shaped primarily by team design, including role clarity, task structures, and access to support. Our team initially demonstrated good design practices by establishing goals, boundaries, regular meetings, record keeping and communication channels (Microsoft Teams) (Hackman, 2002). However, these structures broke down once the simulation commenced. Role clarity eroded, individual goals overshadowed collective ones, and established norms were disregarded. Even when seeking guidance from mentors, improvements were temporary. This reflects the fragility of team design when not actively maintained throughout a project lifecycle.

Conclusion

The Input–Process–Output (IPO) model offers a useful lens to reflect on our group performance (Robbins & Judge, 2019). Inputs such as diverse skills, defined roles, and communication platforms were promising. However, the process stage particularly communication, conflict management, and decision-making was weak, which constrained performance outcomes. While we managed to deliver results in the simulation, this was despite, rather than because of, our group dynamics.

Future Improvements

Communication: A central weakness was ineffective communication. Future teams should encourage structured turn-taking, require evidence-based contributions, and foster openness to alternative perspectives. Communication breakdowns may be explained by Shannon and Weaver's (1949) "noise" concept, and could be addressed by selecting richer media for complex interactions (Daft & Lengel, 1986). Low disclosure and feedback also limited trust and awareness (Luft & Ingham, 1955).

Task Allocation: Although roles were initially defined, they were not adhered to during the simulation. In future, tasks should be allocated based on members' strengths (Belbin, 1981), with accountability mechanisms to ensure contributions are equitable and consistent.

Conflict Resolution: Avoiding conflict resolution perpetuates stress and inefficiency. Future teams should embrace timely conflict discussions and apply structured negotiation techniques (Fisher, Ury & Patton, 1991) to prevent escalation and improve collaboration.

Reflection-in-Action: Incorporating mid-project check-ins would enable teams to reassess goals, address tensions, and realign roles, consistent with Kolb's experiential learning cycle (Kolb, 1984).

References

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